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Promoting veganism. The effects of film propaganda.

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Prohlášení

Prohlašuji, že jsem bakalářskou práci “Promoting veganism. The effects of film propaganda” vypracovala samostatně za použití v práci uvedených pramenů a literatury.

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Abstrakt

Téma propagandy v kinematografii již mnozí zkoumali kvůli příležitostem, které má k ovlivňování názorů lidí. Z tohoto hlediska dokumentární filmy jsou zvláště účinné. Zdá se však, že veganská propaganda je ve studiích prováděných za účelem zjištění jejího vlivu nedostatečně zastoupena. Teoretická část bakalářské práce definuje nejpoužívanější nástroje propagandy podle Institut for Propaganda Analysis. V rámci čtvrté a páté kapitoly aplikují tyto nejpoužívanější nástroje na tvorbu nacistické a sovětské filmové propagandy. Po definování nejúčinnějších nástrojů v praktické části analyzují propagandistické rysy v nedávném úspěšném filmu „Seaspiracy“, který zohledňuje téma udržitelného rybolovu. Kromě toho práce se zaměřuje na vizuální nástroje a výrazové prostředky kinematografie, které pomohly předat poselství. Tato část práce pokračuje kvantitativním výzkumem prostřednictvím dotazníkového šetření. Jeho cílem je pochopit, zda diváci filmu dokázali rozpoznat propagandu použitou ve filmu. Práce nabízí empirická data, která ukazují úroveň účinnosti propagandy. Výsledek výzkumu ukazuje, že z 30 lidí, kteří před sledováním filmu jedli ryby, 21 uvažovalo o změně stravovacích zvyků.

Klíčová slova

Vegan propaganda, transfer, plain folks, montáž, falešné dilema.

Abstract

The topic of propaganda in cinematography has been explored by many because of the opportunity movies have to influence peoples' opinions. Particularly effective at this task are documentaries. Vegan propaganda seems to be underrepresented in studies conducted to determine its influence. The theoretical part of the thesis defines propaganda tools according to the Institute for Propaganda Analysis. Moreover, in the fourth and fifth chapters, I look into the devices used to influence the audiences of Nazi and Soviet propaganda. After defining the most effective tools, in the practical part, I analyse propaganda traits in the recent successful film "Seaspiracy", which brings up the topic of sustainable fishing. Moreover, I focus on the filmmaking techniques and expressive means of cinematography that helped to convey the message of the film. This part of the thesis continues with quantitative research, particularly survey research. Its goal is to understand whether the audience of the film was able to recognise propaganda in the movie. The thesis offers empirical data, that show the level of the effectiveness of propaganda. The result of the research shows that out of 30 people who ate fish before watching the movie, 21 did consider changing their eating habits.

Keywords

Vegan propaganda, transfer, plain folks, montage, false dilemma.

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1. Introduction

How do slogans, misanthropic appeals or simply absurd statements stop causing laughter or horror and become the beliefs of millions? Which propaganda tools can help convey the message to the right person at the right moment?

The choice of the topic for my theses is not accidental. Propaganda, misinformation and fake news were haunting me for the past year since I have started to immerse myself in the world of politics. Nowadays, it is nearly impossible to believe information or data presented in articles, TV or documentary films without fact-checking. Cinematography offers a propagandist a tremendous opportunity to convey a message in a form of ready-made images. The viewer will unconsciously perceive them left with no time to process the footage critically. Unlike in literature, there is no freedom to imagine and comprehend events. The director, screenwriter, director of photography and composer manipulate the audience's emotions in the desirable direction. This has made cinema the most effective weapon for influencing public opinion during the twentieth century. Nowadays, in my opinion, cinema lost its superiority to social media, however, propaganda still manages to find a way to influence opinions.

The primary goal of the thesis is to examine the impact of propaganda used in present documentary films. What is more, it will provide empirical data on the subject by reviewing the results of an online survey. The film shown to the respondents is "Seaspiracy". I chose it because of its recent very successful premiere on Netflix, and the publicity it got after. The movie uses expressive means to convey the half-truth facts and influence peoples' eating habits.

To achieve the goal, I had set the following tasks:

- to define the term propaganda,
- to outline the features of propaganda in cinematography,
- to conduct a comparative analysis of Soviet cinema and Nazi Germany cinema,
- to highlight features of propaganda in "Seaspiracy",
- to examine the answers in the online survey.

In the first part of the thesis, I define the term propaganda, identify propaganda devices used in media and then apply the knowledge to analyse Soviet Russia and Nazi propaganda films. In the second part, I analyse the movie "Seaspiracy" and its propaganda traits. I do not focus on expressive means only but also debunk some of the incorrect information presented in the film.

2. Definition of the concepts used in the thesis

In the next chapter, I will define the terms and concepts used in the thesis, particularly cinema (film) space and documentary film limits.

2.1 Film (cinema) space

A term "cinema (film) space" is used in the theses as a feeling of an integral structure of physical space hidden outside the screen. A French critic André Bazin wrote about this phenomenon: when the character leaves the frame, we admit he escapes from the field of view of the camera but continues to exist as he is, in a unique environment, hidden from us (Bazin, 1972, p. 175).

Cinema space acts under its internal orders. It is a reality constructed according to the intention of the film crew. The frame, even though Bazin characterized it as a cast of reality, is not fully such (Bazin, 1972, p. 17). The visual "cast" is constantly saturated with additional semantic meanings, which are selected by the director.

2.2 Documentary film limits

Although the constructed reality operates inside the imagination, it can strongly influence the audience. The frame is only a part of the depicted whole, and what happens outside of it is a space for imagination. The illusion of reality is a major part of the art of cinema.

Despite the fact that some feature films could change our views on the subject, the realness of documentary films affects the lives of the audience much more strongly.

Consciousness manipulation techniques are capable of destroying knowledge gained from real historical experience, replacing it with knowledge artificially constructed by the director. This is a line where reality and fiction limits are blurred, and the audience needs to make an effort to distinguish between the truth and the lies. During a screening, viewers are not only exposed to their emotions but also to the emotions of the surrounding crowd. It is a perfect opportunity for a propagandist to take advantage of the audience's state of mind and the lack of knowledge.

To sum up the chapter, I defined the term film space based on Bazin's film theory. I also explored the influence of documentary film realness.

3. Destructive propaganda in documentary cinema. Tools used in propaganda

In this chapter, I will explain the definition of the term propaganda used in the thesis. What is more, I will list several devices that are typically used for propaganda analysis. The end of the paragraph is dedicated to the devices used specifically in cinema. Particularly, montage, use of sound or music, an excessive number of symbols, euphemisms and use of maps.

Propaganda forms an artificial picture of the historical reality that is transmitted to individuals through books, lectures, radio and television, press, theatrical performances, films, etc. Thus, an illusory world is built, which is perceived as real (Sorochenko, 2002).

Cinematography is especially effective at this task. Films can have an extremely high emotional impact. Movies actively generate a highly idealized, illusory picture of the world in the viewer's imagination. In accordance with the author's intention, cinema can arbitrarily create a sense of justice and moral rightness of a particular character, regardless of his actual role in the story. Propaganda influence on a person occurs latently, on an emotional level, outside of his conscious control. No rational counterargument works in this case (Sorochenko, 2002).

The choice of documentary film as a material for research is not accidental. Documentary cinema is appealing to a propaganda specialist: its concept means, by default, the veracity of everything shown on the screen.

The definition of propaganda used in the theses comes from Taylor Richard. In "Film propaganda: Soviet Russia and Nazi Germany" he defines it as *"the attempt to influence public opinions of an audience through the transmission of ideas and values"* (Taylor, p. 15).

In the next paragraphs, I will outline basic propaganda devices used not only in cinema but all over the media. These instruments can seem too simplistic; however, they are the most widely known for propaganda analysis (Delwiche, 2018).

3.1 Name-calling

This technique includes a choice of offensive epithets, metaphors, titles and names to label a person, organization, idea. The labels cause a negative emotional connection to the presented information. This usually results in the crowd accepting a conclusion with a superficial consideration of the available evidence (Delwiche, 2018).

3.2 Glittering generalities

It includes replacing the name of a certain social phenomenon, idea, organization, social group or a specific person with a more generic name, which has a positive emotional connotation. It

is based on the exploitation of people's positive feelings and emotions. For example, freedom, democracy, patriotism, commonwealth, peace, happiness, love, success. In the case of glittering generalities propagandist hopes that the audience will approve of the idea without considering the evidence (Delwiche, 2018).

3.3 Euphemisms

Using bland and inoffensive words or images to describe horrifying events (Delwiche, 2018). The technique is used to avoid taboos. Movies are exposed to various, sometimes contradictory censorship systems, which lead to the creation of taboos and euphemisms. For example, we rarely see suicide or mass killing on screen. One of the most known events that are covered by euphemisms in cinematography is execution. If depicted incorrectly, such images of death can distort the director's vision for the film. By focusing on the gory details of the characters' execution, the audience loses interest in the emotional part of the plot (Jerzy, 1967).

3.4 Transfer

An attempt of a propagandist to transfer the authority and the prestige of something accepted in the community to ideals he wants the audience to believe in (Delwiche, 2018).

3.5 Testimonial

The technique comprises citing the statements of individuals with high authority or those that cause a negative reaction. The statements usually contain judgments concerning people, ideas, events, programs, organizations and express condemnation or approval. Thus, these individuals start the formation of an appropriate attitude - emotionally positive or negative. *"The most common misuse of testimonials is to quote individuals, who are not qualified to make judgments on a particular issue"* (Delwiche, 2018).

3.6 Plain Folks

This technique establishes trusting relationships with the audience. The communicator tries to show that he is just like the rest of us. The ideas, suggestions and statements of the propagandist are good because they belong to the common people (Delwiche, 2018).

3.7 Bandwagon

A propagandist uses a selection of judgements, statements and phrases to persuade a whole social group, for example, religious people, to follow the rest of the crowd (Delwiche, 2018).

3.8 False dilemma

The technique is not classified as a propaganda tool but is often used in documentary films. It includes unfairly presenting too few choices and then implying that a choice must be made among them. This oversimplifies the decision making by excluding viable alternatives (Dowden, n.d.).

As I already stated at the beginning of the paragraph, the devices listed above can be used in any media. Now I would like to focus on tools used specifically in cinematography.

3.9 Montage

Famous soviet director Kuleshov thought of a frame as raw material, which, depending on the content of the whole scene, may mean something different. (Jerzy, 1967). By putting two completely unrelated shots together, the editor creates a thought or an emotion that can influence the audience. There are several types of montage, however, in the thesis, I will only speak about montage techniques in the Soviet Union and Nazi Germany.

3.10 Framing

A director chooses an angle, composition and size of the shot to influence the audience's emotions. The technique works secretly: the ordinary viewer usually has no time or knowledge to process the look of the shot and understand how it affects his emotions (Jerzy, 1967).

3.11 Use of sound or music

Sound is a very powerful tool in the hands of a propagandist. It is capable of manipulating emotions on its own, without the image. It changes the perception of the scene in a drastic manner. I will continue the explanation of this technique in the paragraph about cinema in Nazi Germany.

3.12 Use of maps

Visual presentation of the data is much more appealing to the audience than bare voiceover. It is a well-known fact that we as humans receive and can remember more information when we visualize it. This technique was primarily used in movies that described hostilities and the progress of conquest.

3.13 Narration

The use of voice-over in documentary films is a powerful tool, which can be used to limit the audience's thoughts to a specific subject or opinion. It is not uncommon for documentaries to use language as the main medium for conveying the message while using images to illustrate the spoken word. This documentary mode is usually referred to as expository (Nichols, 2010). Some argue that voiceover can guide and structure the audience's vision. There are several studies regarding this phenomenon, for example, Gary Lupyan and Daniel Swingley have found that hearing the name of the object compared to simply thinking about it can temporarily make the visual system a better "object detector" (Swingley & Lupyan, 2006). This indicates that voiceover can force an audience to pay attention to the exact elements that are mentioned. As a result, the audience ignores many other noticeable details.

In this chapter, I have listed several tools that I will use to analyse Soviet and Nazi propaganda. The result of the analysis will later help me to identify propaganda traits in the film "Seaspiracy".

4. Soviet cinema in the 1920s. Themes and characteristics

In this chapter, I will analyse Soviet propaganda using the tools listed above. The main focus is the montage.

4.1 Soviet cinematography of the 1920s

After the revolution, the Soviet government was trying to find a way to unify the widely spread population of the country. The vast majority of the people were illiterate and spoke different languages. This gave cinema a task to convey the message in the simplest way possible. (Taylor, 1998).

4.2 Typical characteristics of Soviet films

The government strictly controlled the themes of the films. There were little to no movies that showed contemporary issues, for example, the industrialisation of agriculture. Some of the films even legitimised the new regime by creating false visualisation of reality (October). What is more, when the import of movies from Germany and the USA stopped, the audience's only choice was to watch Soviet produced propaganda (Taylor, 1998).

The films did not show life as it was, rather they showed life as it will be. The inevitable happy ending was a mandatory characteristic of Soviet movies (Taylor, 1998).

4.2.1 The main character

Due to the ideology being anti-class-based, the major enemy of the people is a self-seeking individual. It can be a landowner, capitalist, priest. Their opponent represents a mass. He or she is usually portrayed as a worker. Their key characteristics are optimism, courage and self-sacrificing (Taylor, 1998). Quite frequently we can see glittering generalities technique in action. We are bombarded with the word freedom, peace, land and bread.

4.2.2 Woman's role

Women were depicted as equal to men. Although their role in society transformed dramatically, many still found themselves in the kitchen with minimal to no responsibilities (Taylor, 1998). We can say that it is an indicator of transfer technique. Bolsheviks tried to associate themselves with liberal ideas and values.

4.2.3 The cult of Lenin and Stalin

This point is self-explanatory. People wanted a new God, and they got it. The roles two leaders played in history were changed to benefit the current regime (Taylor, 1998). Almost every film depicted Lenin and Stalin as “plain folks”. They are wearing “normal people” clothes, always find themselves in the company of workers.

4.2.4 Montage

Montage was the main technique used in Soviet filmmaking. In the next paragraph, I will try to understand what its purpose was, and what the technique achieved. I have chosen film “October” for the analyses. It is unique considering it influenced the perception of the October revolution for many years to come.

Firstly, the film’s director Sergei Eisenstein thought that montage is a collision of two drastically different shots, from which the concept is born. From his point of view, a harmonic connection is just a special case. The most famous result of his work is the intellectual montage. *“Whereas idea and image are completely synonymous in the first shot of the sequence, they grow further apart with each subsequent image”* (Taylor, p. 69). Let’s dissect the scene from “October”, which is a prime example of intellectual montage. We first see titles that tell us the march is in the name of God and Fatherland (figure 1). The audience now has a certain expectation of which shots will come next. For example, church, icon or priest (figure 2). However, after Eisenstein begins the sequence with the church, he tries to distort it in our minds by using odd angles (figure 3). The film continues by showing idols that do not match the audience’s concept of God (figure 4 – figure 8). *“Here a conflict arises between the concept of God and its symbolisation. From this we are to draw anti-religious conclusions as to what the divine as such really is”* (Taylor, pp. 179-180).



Figure 1. The march is in the name of God and Fatherland



Figure 2. The first sight of the church



Figure 3. Example of the odd angles



Figure 4. Beginning of the intellectual montage



Figure 5. Continuation of the intellectual montage



Figure 6. Further distancing the idea of God from the church

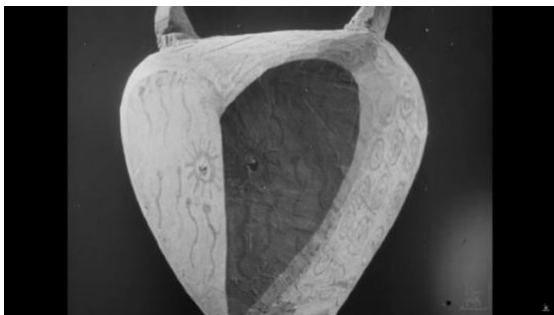


Figure 7. The comparison of the religion with its archaic past



Figure 8. Further lowering religion in the eyes of the viewer

“Whereas the conventional film directs and develops the emotions, here we have a hint of the possibility of likewise developing and directing the entire thought process”. (Taylor, pp. 179-180).

We do not see this type of montage that often anymore. However, it had a major influence on editors and directors all over the world. Editing to this day influences the way the audience perceives certain messages.

In this chapter, I described the most used devices of Soviet propaganda films. I will later use them to identify propaganda features in the film “Seaspiracy”.

5. Nazi propaganda

In this chapter, I will try to understand why Nazi propaganda was so successful. What is more, I will outline its basic characteristics. To achieve this, I will use devices listed in the chapter two, particularly the use of music and maps.

5.1 Nazi cinematography

The propaganda of Nazi Germany was extremely comprehensive: it affected radio, news, magazines, music and of course cinema. The government fully controlled all media. Due to the fact that the new regime was passively accepted among the population, Nazi propaganda could afford to be less aggressive in comparison with Bolsheviks (Taylor, 1998). That is why they were able to produce less obviously political movies and could concentrate more on “educational” ones (Taylor, 1998).

5.1.1 The community before the individual

This approach to life is similar to the one we saw in Soviet movies. It was quite easily accepted by the population due to Christianity being a part of the German cultural tradition (Taylor, 1998). Moreover, quite frequently we can see the use of the “plain folks” technique. It primarily shows that Nazi generals either once were or are now ordinary people.

5.1.2 History parallels

Directors picked major historical figures that were presented as role models. They were used to set an example for future generations. The most famous of them are Frederick the Great and Bismarck. After seeing films about the courage of those great Germans and their love for the country, people were able to recognize the role of Hitler, which was depicted the same way in newsreels. This made people see a mirror image of their own time (Taylor, 1998). In addition, transfer technique appeared frequently in movies, for example, “Triumph of the Will”. Thus, loyalty to the ruling party equalled loyalty to the whole country: *“One people, one Fuhrer, one Reich - Germany”* (Taylor, p. 167) or *“Long live the National Socialist movement! Long live Germany!”* (Taylor, p. 172)

Now let’s look at the expressive means that were used in Nazi cinematography.

5.1.3 The use of the maps

The Nazis took advantage of the fact that pictures affect subconscious and nervous systems. To evoke specific emotions from the audience, they used maps, which accompanied not only strategic explanations, but appeared whenever symbolic presentation was called for

(Kracauer, 1966). *“Resembling graphs of physical processes, they show how all known materials are broken up... by the new one, thus demonstrating its absolute superiority...”* (Kracauer, p. 279)



Figure 9. *The conquest of the Soviet Russia in the film "Victory in the West"*

5.1.4 Music in the movies

Movies usually begin this an overture. The audience is therefore being lulled into submission (Taylor, 1998). *“Accompanying the procession of pictures and statements, music not only deepens the effects produced through these media, but ... introduces new effects or changes the meaning of synchronized units. Music, and music alone, transforms an English tank into a toy. In other instances, musical themes remove the weariness from soldier faces, or make several moving tanks symbolize the advancing German army.”* (Kracauer, p. 280)

5.1.5 Editing

The Nazi film propaganda did not follow the montage rules created in Soviet Russia. *“They did not try to elicit reality from a meaningless arrangement of shots but nipped in the bud any real meaning their candid-camera work might convey. Nothing was neglected in camouflaging this procedure and in bolstering the impression that, through unfaked newsreel material, reality itself was moving across the screen”* (Kracauer, p. 297). Many of the shots in these movies are usually undesirable for directors, however, to make their propaganda feel more real, Nazis did not edit them out (Kracauer, 1966).

In conclusion, we can see that although the ideology of the two countries differed, the way the government used propaganda was quite alike. We were able to determine that majority of the tools described in chapter three were similarly utilised by both countries. Particularly, “plain folks”, “glittering generalities” and “transfer”. With this knowledge, I am now going to look into modern-day propaganda, particularly vegan propaganda.

6. Modern-day propaganda

We might have convinced ourselves that we learned the lesson of the past, and such obvious techniques as “plain folks” or “transfer” will not affect our perception of information. However, as I stated earlier, the devices influence us subconsciously, so there is no way of knowing that we have been subject to propaganda unless we know what to look for. Additionally, modern-day propaganda does not use outrageous lies rather it mixes them with the facts or manipulates the facts to create a narrative. It is particularly interesting to examine vegan propaganda because the topic of eating habits finds an audience all over the world.

6.1 Methodology

In the next paragraph, I will dissect the movie “Seaspiracy” using the method of Kirstin Thompson and David Bordwell and try to find propaganda traits in the film. I will use the devices described in the third, fourth and fifth chapters.

6.2 “Seaspiracy”

“Seaspiracy” is a movie directed by Ali Tabrizi. It quickly became popular among the public because of the issues it talks about. It was realised at the end of March 2021 and attracted a lot of media attention. It paints the fishing industry in a way that would benefit the movie. The director fails to interview different marine biologists and researchers, who would have brought a deeper understanding to the issue and paint a more nuanced picture of the reality. I think it is necessary to say that the authors of the movie bring to light important problems of the field, however, it is obvious that their major goal is to change people’s mind on the subject of eating fish. To achieve this, they need to find arguments to persuade the audience. This is where vegan propaganda comes into play. People do not care about the suffering of the animals, however, nowadays almost everyone is concerned with environmental problems. The director of the movie uses this to his advantage and exploits the facts to pressure the audience into not eating fish. It is painfully apparent that the director does not care about solving the problems of the fishing industry. If this was the case, the information would have been presented by the professionals of this field with all the nuances. Some may say that the film does a good deed, and the way people are influenced into changing their habits does not matter. However, manipulation of the facts and creating a villain of the story harm the fishing industry and the animals in the long run and undermines the sincerity of the film.

This being said, I will not concentrate on debunking all the incorrect information presented in the movie, although I will comment on some of it. I will instead focus on the cinematography tools that helped to convey the message of the film. What is more, it is not my intention to discredit veganism or the authors of the movie. My main goal is to analyse the propaganda devices used and to determine their effectiveness.

Some can say that all documentary films use specific technics to influence people and it does not make them a piece of propaganda. I can agree with this statement, however, manipulation of the facts, hiding the real purpose of the movie and not showing a nuanced picture of the industry makes me believe that “Seaspiracy” is a propaganda film.

Firstly, the name of the movie should itself be a red flag for the audience. We should take into consideration the fact that conspiracies prove themselves right in extremely rare cases. In my opinion, the choice of this name was a conscious decision of the director to attract both positive and negative media attention. This leads me to question the director’s intentions and ask myself: is he willing to manipulate facts to prove his point, or the film will present a two-sided and honest discussion? Moreover, the film created poorly justified scepticism against science and scientists, who have been working on the issues presented in the film for their whole life.

6.2.1 “Plain folks”, “Scapegoat”

NGOs, conservation organisations and government structures are depicted in the film as scapegoats. We have seen a similar technique used in the Soviet and Nazi propaganda, where people were set against a particular group. What is more, as we have previously seen in other films mentioned here, the director of the movie appears to be “one of us”. He learns about the issues of the fishing industry along with us. This way he is not putting any pressure on the viewer at the beginning of the film and builds a trusting relationship with the audience.

6.2.2 “Name-calling”

The director uses the word “corrupted” when speaking about organisations, which provide sustainable fishing labels, however, he does not present any proof to support this claim. The word “corruption” thus affects the viewer’s perception of these companies, which results in a lack of trust towards sustainable fishing practices in general.

6.2.3 False dilemma

The director of the movie presents only two choices to the audience: to stop eating fish completely or to stay the part of the problem. The nuances of the other choices are not explained properly because the goal of the movie is to make people quit eating fish. The technique unfairly narrows viewer’s options, depriving the audience of the possibility to make an educated decision.

6.2.4 Testimonial

One of the biggest criticisms of the movie is a lack of nuanced discussion between the scientists, who devoted their lives to the problems presented in the film. Instead of interviewing specialists of the field that present different points of view, the documentary chooses to pick the scientists that are supporting the film’s message. One of the marine biologists, Prof. Callum Roberts, who has the qualifications to talk about the issues discussed in the film, supports the vegan narrative, however, even he points out the wrong data presented in the film. In his point of view, the film does not need to be scientifically correct. It

conveys the message that humanity is doing a huge amount of damage to the ocean. To him, the end justifies the means (McVeigh, 2021). However, another Professor Christina Hicks (Environmental social scientist at Lancaster Environment Centre) did not agree with the film's narrative and felt like the movie was damaging to the industry and scientists (Hicks, 2021).

Another example of the film picking scientists that support the vegan narrative is the fact that the director interviews Richard Oppenlander. He is a dentist and refers to himself as a consultant, researcher and lecturer on the topics of food choice and sustainability. What is more, he owns an organic vegan food production company and operates an animal sanctuary (Oppenlander, n.d.). The documentary mentions the conflict of interests when speaking about sustainability labels, however, fails to do so in the case of Richard Oppenlander. Additionally, his claims about less than 1% of oceans being regulated were called inaccurate and nonsensical by the NFI (Media, 2021).

6.2.5 Euphemisms

The film does not try to cover any blood or killing in the films; thus, we can say it does not use euphemisms. On the contrary, it emphasizes the cruelty of the fishing industry to further prove its point.

6.2.6 Use of the animation and graphs

The authors use animation and graphs to visually present the data, which, as I stated in the third chapter, make the message feel more real and less abstractive (figure 10 – figure 13).

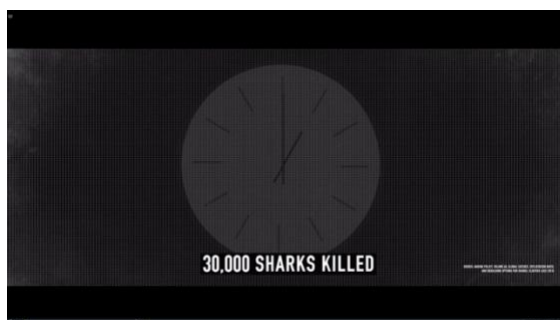


Figure 10. The quantity of sharks killed by people per year



Figure 11. The quantity of people killed by sharks per year

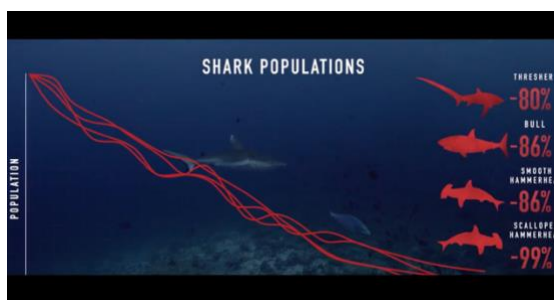


Figure 12. Sharks' population decline.



Figure 13. Representation of the food chain

The director also chose to visualize parts of the film, which will have the most emotional impact. For example, the murder of the woman observer. The scene consists of mostly details, which make the viewer disoriented (figure 14 – figure 16). Furthermore, gunshots are aimed at the audience, ruining the fourth wall and making the danger feel more real.



Figure 14. The gunshot is fired towards the viewer

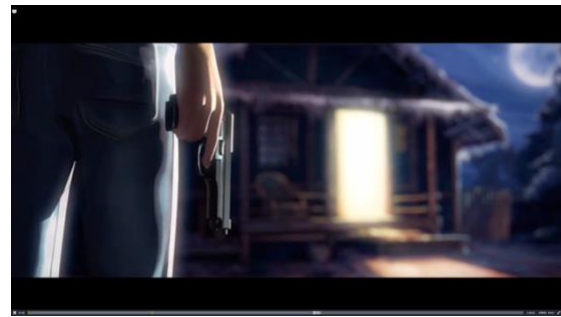


Figure 15. The shot is filmed from the back making the viewer a witness of the crime.

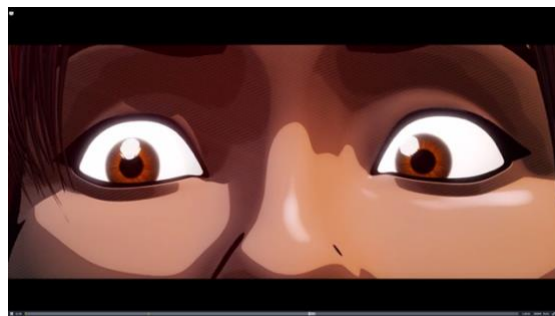


Figure 16. Detail of the eyes of the victim

6.2.7 Narration

The director tells the audience what conclusions it should draw from the material through the voiceover. Usually, this type of narration will be considered repetitive and unengaging, but in this case, the author uses it to install thoughts in the viewers' minds. As I previously stated in the third chapter, voiceover can make the audience notice one statement and ignore the other. Moreover, through the voiceover director tries to get closer to the audience and show that he is on the viewer's side. He does not believe the information given to him until he checks the sources himself. For example, he makes sure that he is told the truth about the slavery in prawn industry. It also makes the film feel more reliable.

Another significant part of the plot is the reiteration of the suggestion that sustainable fishing does not exist. It is a thought that can be tracked throughout the movie.

At the end of the film, we can clearly see its true intentions. Rather than make a closing statement about the theme of the movie (environmental effects of industrial fishing), the director starts to preach about the suffering of the animals pretending to learn all the

information about it just now. This makes the film sound extremely pretentious and untrustworthy.

6.2.8 Editing

From the beginning of the movie, the director shows us the people we can believe, experts, who are on our side. Later we see monologues of people with the opposite point of view. The film edits interviews of these people to contradict each other. However, since at the beginning of the movie we were shown our heroes, we continue to believe them. Not only did the montage affect the order of the scenes but also the context in which the interviews were given, which led to misleading claims.

Before the trip to Thailand, one of the experts warns the director: *“If you are getting in their way, you are risking your own life”* (Seaspiracy, 2021). When we hear “you are” on the screen we see the director. This way of editing makes the phrase sound less abstract and influences the audience to feel for the director. Moreover, creating a mysterious and dangerous atmosphere around the trip takes away attention from the main subject of the film and makes it about the director’s courage.

During this trip, while interviewing a victim, the film crew gets a warning about the police coming. We see shots of the crew packing their belongings and getting away in their car. We then see a police car getting in the direction of the place where the interview was held. This makes the audience get a feeling of relief and further underlines the dangerous atmosphere. The crew was packing their stuff during the sunset (figure 17), but the police car is shown during pitch-black darkness (figure 18).

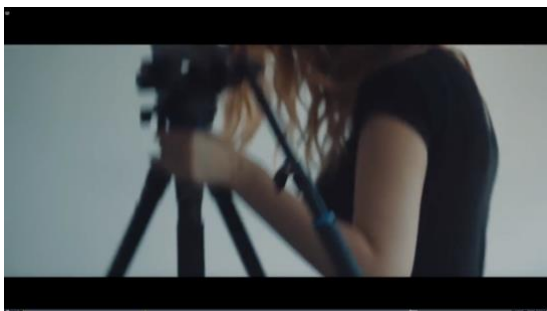


Figure 17. Film crew is packing their belongings during sunset



Figure 18. Police chasing someone in the pitch black

In conclusion, it seems like the danger of the police warning was amplified tremendously, while true events could have been less stressful.

The scene with the slaughter of the whales is particularly interesting in the context of editing. We can see a dramatic change in the rhythm of the film. The last moments of whales’ lives are filmed in a long shot (26 seconds), giving the audience an opportunity to see their beauty. Then the tempo of the film changes to the 1-2 second shots. Among them are shots that consist of a blank screen with the sound of whales squeaking. The chaos of the slaughter is supported by a great number of cuts.



Figure 19. Men running in chaos



Figure 20. Whales with cut throats

We see men running towards the whales in a long shot (figure 19), then in detail. It does not play its usual role of highlighting an important element of the shot. It is used here purely to create more confusion. After that, we see a blank screen with whale squeaking noise. It implies the pain of the slaughter. Then we see the result of the killing: whale gushing blood from its throat (figure 20). Men are shouting and create more confusion in the shot. Again, this shot is only a couple of frames long, it does not give the viewer a chance to see what is going on, rather it amplifies the chaos. The zoom in the shot seems to be invisible as well, but it helps to amplify the effect of confusion and fear tremendously. This sequence: blank screen with the whales squeaking, men shouting and running, whales gushing blood and laying in it is repeated for about one minute. The blank screen shots are obviously used to create a continuous timeline, but they are also extremely emotionally charged. More violent and bloody shots have less screen time, they are used to convey the emotion, not to document the way whales are slaughtered.

The sequence ends with the long shot (9 seconds) of boats swimming in the water looking like sharks hunting the remaining whales (figure 21). While filming, the director touches the face of a dead whale, “breaking” the distance between the viewer and the screen (figure 22). The audience has now not only seen a dead whale but had an opportunity to touch it.



Figure 21. Boats hunting remaining whales



Figure 22. The director touches a dead whale

These shots create such a strong impression in the minds of the viewers therefore the audience becomes prone to subsequent manipulation. The director uses this to his advantage to once again repeat that sustainable fishing does not exist.

We see a shot that refers to the scene in the animated part of the film, a man has a gun in his hand, he is going to kill a woman observer (figure 15). However, in this case, we see a bloody hand, which just slaughtered a whale (figure 23). It creates a direct link between the feelings

that the audience felt during the animation scene and this scene, consolidating the fear and hatred towards a murderer.



Figure 23. Bloody hand of the whaler

6.2.9 Sound

The film uses a lot of dramatic music, which helps to influence the audience's emotions. For example, in the whale slaughter scene, while dead whales are being dragged by the boat towards the coast, we hear vocals that sound like whales. This makes the audience associate the pain of the whales with human pain.

Additionally, music is used to change the mood of the scene or influence the viewer's perception of the expert. If the interviewee seems to struggle to find the answer, we hear comical music. This technique is used during the interview with the Oceana representative. On the other hand, some speeches are accompanied by inspiring music. This works especially well during the last scene of the film, where the director's idol Dr. Sylvia Earle calls on to stop eating animals and make changes.

After the analysis, I can clearly see the elements of propaganda in the film. It used filmmaking techniques to make up a story, rather than to educate people. What is more, it did harm the industry and organisations that have been helping the animals for decades.

In the next part of the chapter, I will focus on the facts that are included in the questionnaire and debunk the untrue statements. I will later see the results and will examine whether the audience was able to recognise the truth.

6.3 Analysis of the half-truths presented in the film

The astonishing fact about oceans being empty by 2048 is simply not true. The director chose to build the story on the old study, which was later contradicted by its author (Aboutseafood, 2009). After the critique in the conservation community, the authors reviewed the paper and gave a much more nuanced and less dramatic view of the future. (Worm, et al., 2009) So, we can speculate, why the film does use such an old and reworked study in the first place? The outrageous claim has done its job and the movie got the popularity it has now. Additionally, there was a study published in 2016 that gave a more optimistic perspective to the issue. It did not have any loud claims about the empty ocean but concluded that common-sense reforms to fishery management would dramatically improve overall fish abundance while increasing food security and profits (Costello, et al., 2016). The film, however, decided to use an outrageous number to shock the audience. This also helped to further promote the lie about the nonexistence of sustainable fisheries.

Another fact that the film used to its advantage is that 46% of the Great Pacific Garbage Patch are fishing nets. This is an example of mixing truth with lies. 46% figure is true to the Great Pacific Garbage Patch; however, it does not indicate the global quantity of plastic in the ocean. The movie fails to cite the best available science — a study published by Eunomia — that fishing gear accounts for only 10-20% of marine plastic globally. The vast majority — at least 80% — comes from land-based sources (Oceana, 2021). The film tells the audience that organisations do not address the issue of the fishing nets in the ocean. However, this is another lie. Basic google research finds that there are groups, that specifically target the nets around the world. Global ghost gear initiative, for example, engages in solving the problem of lost and abandoned fishing nets worldwide (GGGI, n.d.).

The film claims that sustainable fishing does not exist. The director asks an Oceana (the largest international advocacy organization focused solely on ocean conservation (Oceana, 2021)) representative to define sustainable fishing. Maria José Cornax (former Senior Policy & Advocacy Director) seems to struggle to explain sustainability for fisheries and says it can be confusing for the consumer to identify sustainably caught fish. This part of the movie is a couple of minute part of a two-hour interview. After the premiere of the movie, Oceana defends itself and releases a statement concerning the interview. The organization believes that fishing can and must be done in a sustainable way, it helps science-based fisheries all over the world and directs fish-eaters towards buying sustainably produced fish (Oceana, 2021). Organizations like this, who have been concentrating for years on the issues that the film presents, fell a victim to the director's attempt to paint them as corrupted and unbothered institutions. What is more, the movie created doubt in the peoples' minds: do they need to donate to such organizations? This could result in a decrease in donations towards the Oceana and harm the ocean and the animals in the long run.

As I stated at the beginning of the chapter, "Seaspiracy" does use a lot of documentary film techniques to strengthen its arguments and influence people's emotions. However, utilising those instruments does not automatically make a movie a propaganda piece. In my opinion, hiding the purpose of the movie and manipulating the facts does.

7. Analysis of the survey

7.1 Methodology

To examine people's reaction to the film and to understand the effect of propaganda tools, I used quantitative research, particularly survey research. The method was chosen due to its ability to reach many people and to directly analyse alternative variables. Another advantage is a replication of the research (the survey can be replicated in different settings). However, there are some disadvantages to this method: inability to clarify what the respondent meant, closed-ended questions, which narrow the respondent's view on the problem. There was an attempt on my part to eliminate the latter disadvantage by providing "other" option, where respondents could specify what they meant or express their thoughts. The survey consisted of 29 questions, some of them are open-ended, others had a yes/no option for an answer. The survey had 47 responders in total.

Hypotheses

1. A very small percentage of the respondents will be able to identify propaganda in the movie.

To determine that, I will examine questions concerning the persuasiveness of the experts and the truthfulness of the facts. To identify the veracity of the facts would be equal to recognising that some of the statistics in the film are exaggerated, some of the studies used are old and do not reflect the reality now, thus respondents would need to pick an option, which suggests that facts are not convincing. I suppose that not many people would be able to do that. There are a couple of reasons why. Firstly, the data presented in the film are not commonly known and require a scientist or an expert in the field to be correctly interpreted. Secondly, the audience will be impacted by the visual and sound effects, thus they will be less likely to question the accuracy of the information.

2. Vast majority will find the fact that fishing can be sustainable, not true.

My assumption is based on the fact that this particular information was repeatedly told throughout the film. What is more, the term "sustainable fishing" was constantly discredited by several experts. However, the facts tell us a different story. I will later expand this explanation in the context of the question about the sustainability of fishing.

3. Half of the respondents will not be able to notice filmmaking techniques and their effects. Specifically, editing and sound.

4. The film will persuade half of the fish-eaters to consider changing their eating habits.

The questions of the survey are based on the facts described in the sixth chapter. Some of them concern expressive means of the film, for example, the rhythm and the music others ask about more controversial facts. For example, “Ocean being empty by the year 2048”.

7.2 The goal of the questions in the survey

Now I would like to describe the goal of each question in the survey. After that, I will review the results and draw conclusions.

1. “Do you eat fish?”

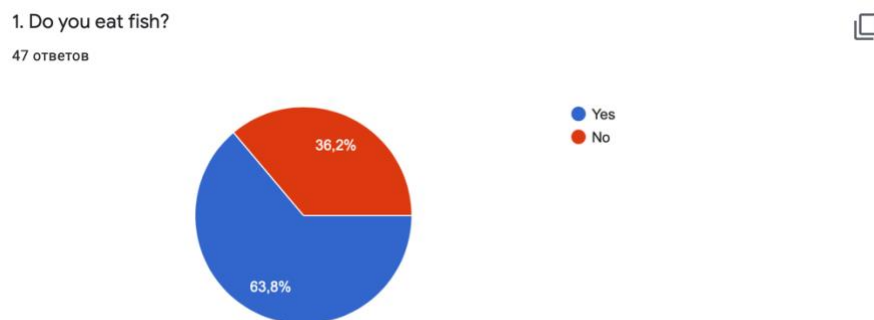


Figure 24. More than 60% of respondents eat fish.

The first question is used to understand a person’s initial relationship with veganism. It also aims to capture the difference in the respondent’s behaviour before and after watching the film: eating or not eating fish.

The answers show that more than 60% of the respondents eat fish, thus they are the ones the film tries to convince to change their ways.

2. “Can you relate to the author’s concerns about the ocean?”

The goal of this question is to determine respondent’s knowledge about the environmental issues surrounding the ocean. The awareness of existing problems can make a person less susceptible to half-truths. On the contrary, people who are unaware of the issues, perceive the information as a full truth. It is hard to blame them for it. The facts are presented in the best way possible. The interviews are cut to be shorter, and the experts speak straight to the point. What is more, the information is illustrated with astonishing images of the ocean creatures and data graphs.

2. Can you relate to the author's concerns about the ocean?

47 ответов

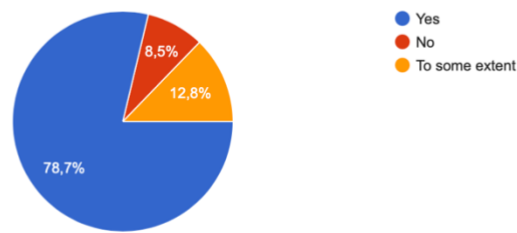


Figure 25. More than 80% of the respondent could relate to the director's concerns.

According to the results of the survey, more than 80% of respondents (including the “to some extent” option) show interest in problems surrounding the ocean.

3. “Have you heard about the problems of the fishing industry before watching the film?”

3. Have you heard about the problems of the fishing industry before watching the film?

47 ответов

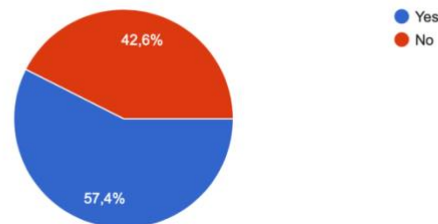


Figure 26. Almost 60% are familiar with the problems of the fishing industry.

Once again, I'm trying to understand the level of respondent's knowledge in this field and their potential of being influenced by the facts.

The survey showed that almost 60% have heard about the problems of the industry, majority of them also share the director's concerns (answered yes to the previous question).

4. “Did you memorize any of the numbers or statistics in the film?”

I highly doubt that people who are casually watching a movie will try to remember statistics and numbers to later research their accuracy.

4. Did you memorize any of the numbers or statistics in the film? (please, specify which)



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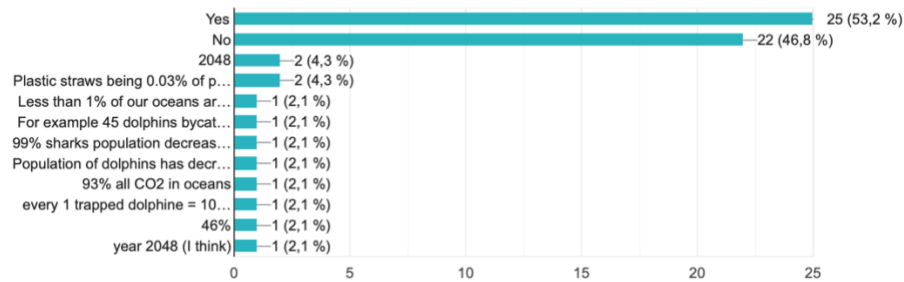


Figure 27. 53% of the respondent did memorize specific statistics.

My assumption turned out to be wrong. 53% of the respondents memorized specific data. Some people even were able to recall statistics that stood out to them. Among them are, for example, the fact that less than 1% of the oceans are protected and a 97% decrease in shark's population. Moreover, one of the respondents was able to remember that one fishing vessel killed 45 dolphins to catch 18 tuna. (The person remembered the fact incorrectly, the vessel slaughtered 45 dolphins to catch 8 tuna. However, even that ratio was so nerve-racking that they could recall it afterwards). Three people remembered the fact about the ocean being empty by the year 2048.

5. “Do you find the experts of the movie convincing?”

Propaganda tool used: testimonial.

The film tries to discredit some of the experts by playing comical music during their interviews, while other experts' interviews are accompanied by dramatic sound effects and music. What is more, experts who support the director's point of view do not contradict each other. We see them telling a consistent story. On the other hand, people who present a different point of view are edited to contradict the “trusted experts” of the film. And since they represent the majority, they appear more convincing. In addition, the question has a “some of the experts” answer option. The outcome of the question will influence the confirmation of my hypotheses.

5. Do you find the experts of the movie convincing?



47 ОТВЕТОВ

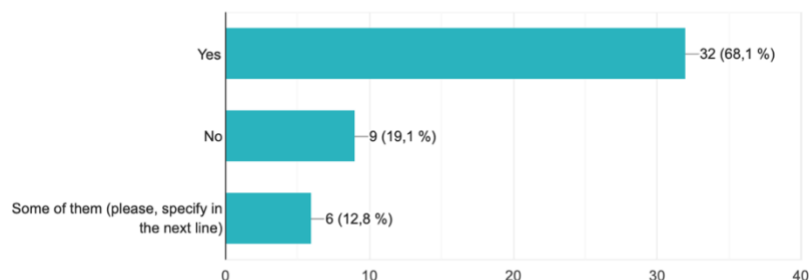


Figure 28. 80% were inclined to believe the experts.

The results of the survey showed a high level of trust in the experts. 68% chose the “yes” option, while 12% chose “some of them”. None of the respondents, who answered the latter option were able to specify, who exactly was convincing. Since people believed the experts, it makes me feel more confident in confirming my first hypothesis.

We can conclude that the testimonial functioned properly.

6. “Did you find the experts of the movie unbiased?”

Propaganda tool used: testimonial.

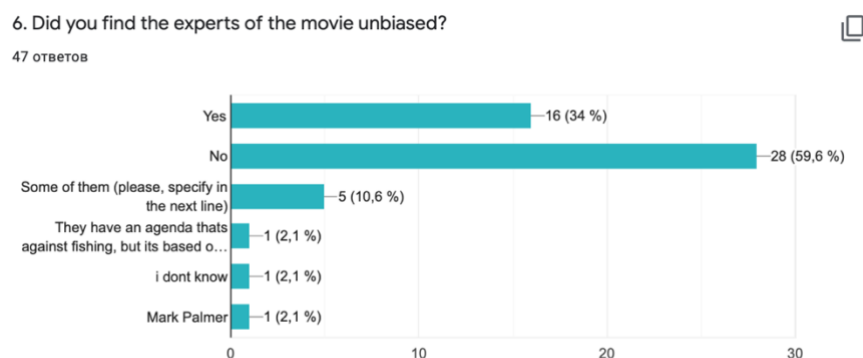


Figure 29. More than half found the experts had no bias.

Similar question to the last one, however, it concentrates more on the reliability of the experts' opinions. To some degree, it should make the respondents think about who benefits from the film.

These answers confirm the effectiveness of the testimonial. Almost half of the respondents found the experts had no bias. One of them said that the experts had an anti-fishing agenda, however, it was based on the facts. Another respondent was able to specify an unbiased expert, Mark J. Palmer.

7. “Did you find the experts of the movie qualified to comment on the issue of sustainable fisheries or plastic pollution?”

Propaganda tool used: testimonial.

Earlier I have made a point about a lack of scientists and professors in the field. In my opinion, the film does not present a nuanced picture of the problem. It seems like the director purposefully picked the parts of the interviews that suited the narrative.

The question aims to see whether the respondents trust the opinions of the experts.

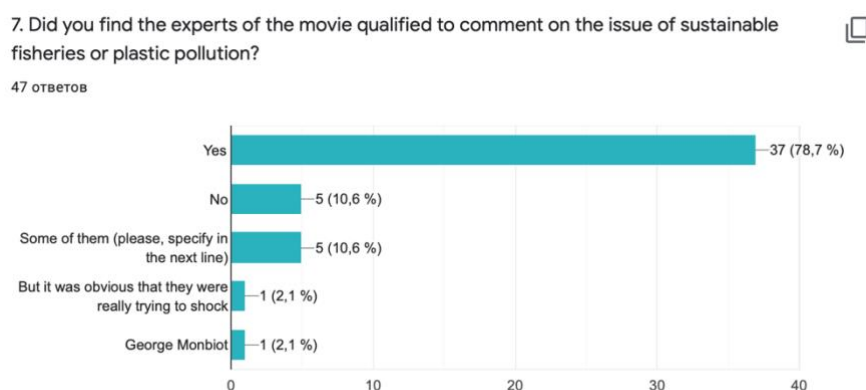


Figure 30. Vast majority thought experts were qualified enough.

According to the answers, the vast majority (79%) found the experts qualified enough to comment on the issues. In addition, one respondent expressed that although the experts were qualified, “it was obvious they tried to really shock people”. Used propaganda tool played its role successfully and was pretty effective.

After reviewing the last three questions, we can conclude that the audience is persuaded in the correctness of the information they receive.

8. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive), how convincing do you find the fact that oceans will be empty by 2048?”

Propaganda tool used: there is no particular one, however, it could be a half-truth since the fact was considered right at one point.

As I already stated in the previous chapter, the film used an old study to shock people into taking action. “Seaspiracy”, despite its successful premiere, got a lot of criticism for that specific statistic, as it has not been used in the scientific literature for many years now. In an interview, the director Ali Tabrizi put an emphasis on the fact that we have to look at an overall trend of the depletion of fish stocks. He added: *“I believe the scientists put forward a statement saying that so long as we follow some sustainable measures – we’re not going to see empty oceans by 2048. I believe that might have been used to justify continuing fishing. But the thing is, that would be dependent on doing those sustainable measures. There’s no real evidence globally that we’re doing that”* (Giliver, 2021). Once again, we can see an example of conspiracy thinking. Instead of telling the viewer that there is a chance to restore the fish population and attract attention to that, Tabrizi decided to show the one possible option: stop eating fish. The film follows this pattern of communicating information in later statistics.

8. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find the fact that oceans will be empty by 2048? 

47 ответов

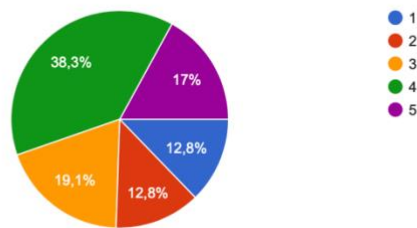


Figure 31. The fact convinced more than half of the respondents.

The majority of the respondents (55%) went for “4” and “5”, which suggests that the fact was perceived as truth. 17% answered the “3” option, which, in my opinion, indicates that it was convincing enough, but maybe they did not have as strong of a reaction to the statistic. This result was expected; however, it is another sign that the propaganda was successful.

9. “Which statement is more worrying to you “Oceans will be empty by 2048” or “The data is showing that fish populations are declining, but can be restored with the common-sense reforms to fishery management”?”

This question is a continuation of the last one. The first statement comes from the film, second – from a study, I have cited earlier in the sixth chapter.

By using this question, I am trying to understand, if more specific data will have a stronger effect on the viewer.

9. Which statement is more worrying to you “Oceans will be empty by 2048” or “The data is showing that fish populations are declining but can be restored with the commonsense reforms to fishery management”? 

47 ответов

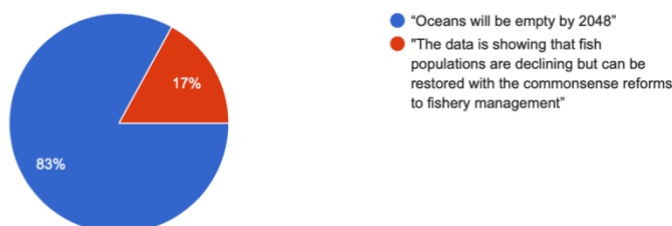


Figure 32. First statement turned out to be more worrying.

As expected, the first answer was more anxiety-inducing than the second one. More than 80% chose the exact data option. It proves my point: if the director was to use the second statement, the film would not have as much publicity as it has now.

10. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive), how convincing do u find the fact that 46% of the Great Pacific Garbage Patch are fishing nets?”

Propaganda tool used: half-truth.

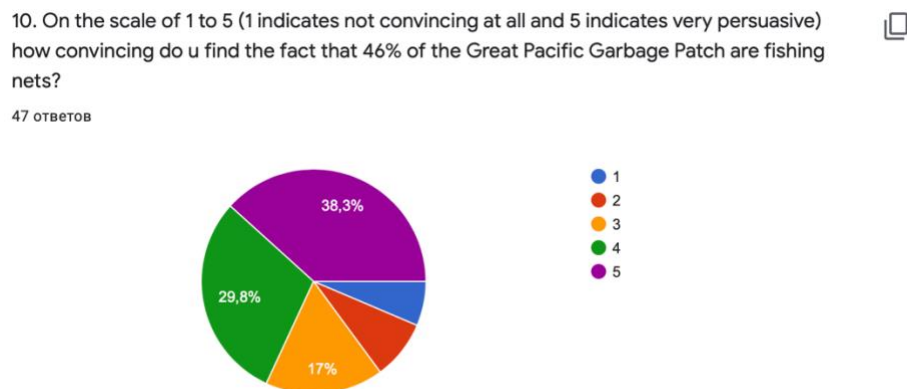


Figure 33. The fact seemed convincing to more than half of the respondents.

The goal of the question is to understand firstly, whether the fact seems to be true to the respondent, secondly whether George Monbiot seems trustworthy enough to be believed. Similar questions are put in the survey in pairs: the respondents answer whether they find the fact accurate and then whether they find a presenter of the fact convincing. I specifically chose some experts to illustrate the difference in the way the film treats their interviews.

As for the accuracy of the fact, I stated in the chapter above that it is a half-truth.

The fact was received as truth and in the context of just this question, it was the truth. More than 68% have chosen a “5”, “4” option. We can estimate that the question about the persuasiveness of George Monbiot will turn out the same way.

11. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive), how convincing do you find Ali Tabrizi (the director of the film)?”

Propaganda tool used: plain folks.

Ali Tabrizi faced a lot of criticism after the premiere of the movie for being pretentious. He does not claim to be an expert in the industry that is why I wanted to check what impression

he did make on the respondents. Also, by using the “plain folks” technique, he got closer to the audience, which could have influenced their perception of him.

The result of the survey highlights that he did have an uncertain impression on the audience. Half of the answers show that he was quite convincing, however, 31% found him to be not persuasive at all. (They chose the “1” and “2” option).

“Plain folks” did not quite help him to appear persuasive to the audience.

11. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find Ali Tabrizi (the director of the film)?



47 ОТВЕТОВ

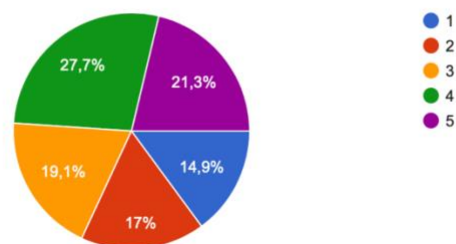


Figure 34. Ali Tabrizi had an uncertain impression on the audience.

12. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive), how convincing do you find Mark Palmer (an executive with the international organisation responsible for the Dolphin Safe tuna label)”.

Propaganda tool used: testimonial. However, here it is used in a different way. Mark Palmer evokes a negative reaction.

12. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find Mark Palmer (an executive with the international organisation responsible for the Dolphin Safe tuna label)



47 ОТВЕТОВ

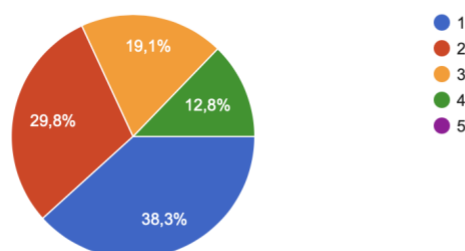


Figure 35. The results show that Mark Palmer appeared to be not convincing to the audience.

Mark Palmer claims his statement about not guaranteeing that every can of tuna is dolphin safe was taken out of context. During the interview in the film, he was repeatedly asked the same question and seemed to struggle to give a satisfying answer. I believe, this did affect his trustworthiness in the eyes of the respondents. However, after the premiere of the movie, he released a statement: *“When asked whether we could guarantee that no dolphins were ever killed in any tuna fishery anywhere in the world, I answered that there are no guarantees in life, but that by drastically reducing the number of vessels intentionally chasing and netting dolphins as well as other regulations in place, that the number of dolphins that are killed is very low. The film took my statement out of context to suggest that there is no oversight, and we don’t know whether dolphins are being killed. This is simply not true. I further explained that there are several layers of review of tuna fishing to confirm that tuna is indeed Dolphin Safe. There are international observers aboard the tuna purse seine vessels that catch tuna for canning. Our International Marine Mammal Project has monitors around the world who routinely check canneries, tuna shipments, storage units, and tuna vessels. The US National Marine Fisheries Service has further jurisdiction to enforce the Dolphin Safe tuna standards for tuna brought into the US, the largest market for canned tuna in the world. Seaspiracy omitted everything related to this explanation, further distorting the truth.”* ((IMMP), 2021).

As expected, the majority found him not convincing at all (67%). This indicates that among all the experts mentioned in the survey, he has the lowest trust rate. This could have been caused by the fact that M. Palmer contradicts himself in the interview quite frequently. We can speculate who is to blame for this outcome: the film or M. Palmer himself. The statement of M. Palmer cited above could be true because the interview has several cuts in it. One of them is after the answer to the question “can you guarantee that every can is dolphin safe?”. Palmer answers “no, nobody can”. In his statement cited above, he claims that in this exact moment he specified: even though he cannot 100% guarantee the safety of the dolphins, the number of killed ones is very low. We will never know the truth until the uncut version of the interview will be released, however, we can clearly see the outcome of the interview and the effects it had on M. Palmer’s trustworthiness.

13. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find Maria José Cornax (Oceana)”

Propaganda tool: testimonial used to cause a negative reaction.

At the end of her interview, while Cornax was struggling to give an answer, there was comical music playing to amplify the fact that Oceana did not want to put an anti-fishing statement on their web page to protect the ocean from plastic pollution. It should have affected the perception of her interview.

In comparison with the previous expert, Maria Cornax had a pretty convincing appearance in the film. 62% of the people thought she was pretty persuasive (option “3” and “4”). It is interesting to see that despite her struggling to find an answer and the use of comical music during that scene, the audience still found her words believable. In my opinion, that could

have been caused by the fact that she supported the director's narrative about the ability of the consumer to make an informed decision on the subject of sustainable fish. However, she never completely agreed with Ali Tabrizi.

The technique did not achieve the desired effect. It did not discredit M. Cornax completely.

13. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find Maria José Cornax (Oceana)

47 ОТВЕТОВ

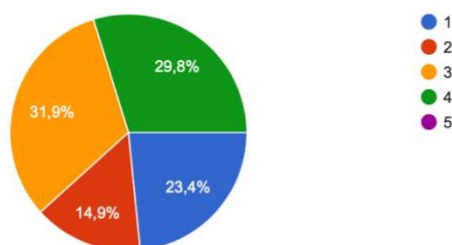


Figure 36. 62% found Maria Cornax persuasive.

14. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find Dr. Sylvia Earle?”

Propaganda tool used: transfer, testimonial.

14. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find Dr. Sylvia Earle?



47 ОТВЕТОВ

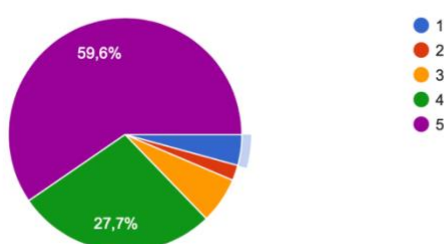


Figure 37. Dr. Sylvia Earle turned out to be the most trusted expert.

Dr. Sylvia Earle is presented in the film as “the expert”. In the beginning of the movie, we see a connection the director has to her work; thus, she is to be trusted. I expect that a lot of respondents will believe her. Besides that, I could not find any incorrect information that she said during the interview.

My expectations exceeded themselves. She is the most trusted expert among the ones in the survey. Almost half of the respondents found her to be very persuasive. 35% chose a “4” option, which still indicates an extremely high percentage (86%) of trust.

Tools worked wonders. Not only is she the most trusted expert, but she also transferred her status in the science community and the respect it has for her to the film.

15. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find George Monbiot?”

Propaganda tool used: transfer, testimonial.

The film shows him as a trustworthy expert, however, the fact that 46% of plastic in the Pacific Garbage patch is fishing nets does not represent the bigger picture. In my opinion, Monbiot knew about that and purposefully decided to use a more shocking statistic.

Knowing the answers to the tenth question about the fishing nets in the Garbage Patch, I think it is very likely he would be one of the more convincing experts. In fact, the answers show 41% found him persuasive and 27% thought of him as very persuasive. In addition, him and Dr. Earle presented themselves as experienced public speakers, while others could not find the right, answer or took too long to think.

15. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do you find George Monbiot?
47 ответов

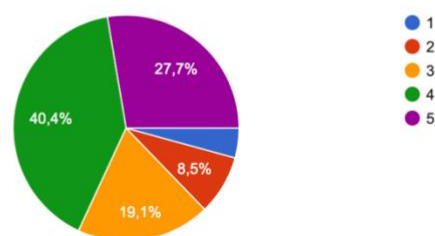


Figure 38. According to the answers, Monbiot was a convincing expert.

Just like the Dr. Sylvia Earle G. Monbiot transfers his authority to the film, making it more reliable in the eyes of the audience.

16. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do u find the fact that tuna safe labels can guarantee that there were no dolphins killed while fishing?”

Propaganda tool used: testimonial used to cause a negative reaction, editing (this scene was edited next to the one, where the statement of M. Palmer gets contradicted).

16. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do u find the fact that tuna safe labels can guarantee that there were no dolphins killed while fishing?

47 ответов

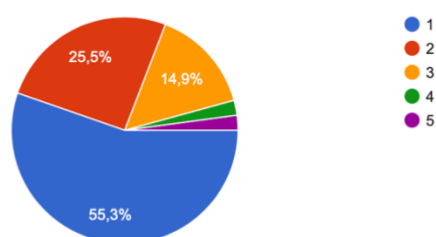


Figure 39. More than half of the respondents did not believe that labels can guarantee the safety of the dolphins.

Since Mark J. Palmer was asked about that, I expect that the fact will be seen by the respondents as not convincing at all.

The trustworthiness of his statement was also influenced by Ric O'Barry. In the following scene after Palmer's interview, he implies a conflict of interest: Earth Island institute gets paid by fishing companies to put the organization's label on their products. This and other scenes in the movie made Earth Island institute put out a statement defending themselves. In it, they said: *"Tuna companies may place a dolphin-safe label on their products without charge so long as their tuna fishery practices comply with federal regulations that there be no capture, netting, injury, or death of dolphins. Companies that comply with the federal regulations and certain additional protective measures may use a licensed logo from the International Marine Mammal Project"* (IMMP, 2021).

The survey shows that almost 60% of the respondents perceived the fact as not convincing at all. It is pretty clear, why the results indicate such low levels. Since the audience did not find the presenter persuasive, they did not believe the thing he advocated for.

17. "On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do u find the fact that fishing can be sustainable?"

Propaganda tool used: narration, false dilemma.

Although during the whole movie the audience is told that fishing cannot be sustainable, scientists disagree. What is more, there are tools *"that provide formal recognition of seafood certification schemes that successfully complete a rigorous and transparent benchmark process, underpinned by the FAO Guidelines. The tool aims to minimize the overall environmental impact of how we produce, catch and supply seafood to meet a growing global demand."* (Global Sustainable Seafood Initiative, n.d.).

17. On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates not convincing at all and 5 indicates very persuasive) how convincing do u find the fact that fishing can be sustainable?

47 ОТВЕТОВ

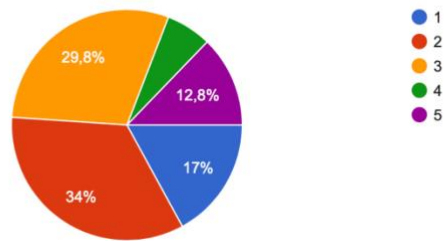


Figure 40. The audience thought that fishing cannot be sustainable.

The fact that this statement is repeated extensively during the whole movie definitely had an effect on the audience. What is more, it is repeated once again after one of the most emotionally charged scenes (whale slaughter). The only solution to the problem according to the film is to eliminate fish consumption. The audience should make a choice: whether they continue to be a part of the problem or stop eating seafood and become a part of the solution. This, in my opinion, this is an indicator of a false dilemma.

Reviewing the outcome of the survey, we can definitely see a propaganda tool effect here: the most highly answered option (34%) is “2”, which clearly shows that people are sure that fishing could not be done sustainably. This is a direct consequence of two scenes: the interview with M. Palmer and the whale slaughter scene.

18. “Did you find the narrator repetitive?”

18. Did you find the narrator repetitive?

47 ОТВЕТОВ

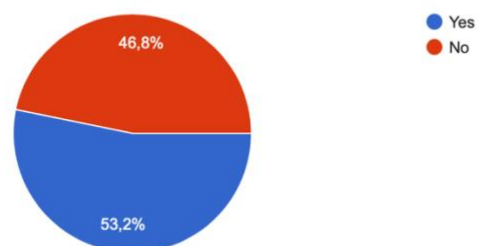


Figure 41. Half of the audience thought the narrator was repetitive.

During the whole film, the audience repeatedly hears about the fact that there is no such thing as sustainable fish, and the only way to solve the problem of overfishing is to stop eating seafood. I was trying to understand whether the respondents did notice that.

The results are ambiguous. 53% of the respondents found the narrator repetitive. The fact that they could notice that in the sea of new information indicates the level of reiteration.

19. “On the scale of 1 to 5 (1 indicates unbothered and 5 indicates very disturbed) how did the whale slaughtering scene make you feel?”

Propaganda tool used: editing.

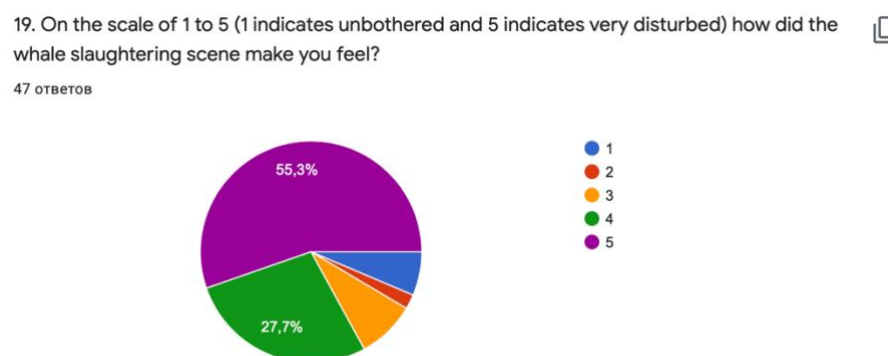


Figure 42. 83% were disturbed by the scene.

I consider that scene to have the most potential to affect the viewers. It speaks to the most primal feelings: fear and anger. In addition, after this scene, we can clearly see a shift in the film narrative. Since the grind (whale slaughter) was done sustainably, the movie had no chances to find an argument that will discredit that. They had to show the real purpose of the film.

The outcome of the question shows that, indeed, 83% of the people were very disturbed by the scene. There was almost no one that remained unbothered. The outcome shows that the scene affected both people eating and not eating fish.

20 “Did you notice dynamic editing in the whale slaughter scene? If yes, please answer the next question”

In the previous chapter, I analysed this particular scene, however, I wanted to understand whether respondents were aware of the filmmaking technique and how it affected them. If they were, I think it is fair to assume it would have a different effect on them. Still, the audience would be very disturbed but would be aware of the director choosing to make the scene this way for a particular reason.

20. Did you notice the dynamic editing in the whale slaughter scene? If yes, please answer the next question



47 ответов

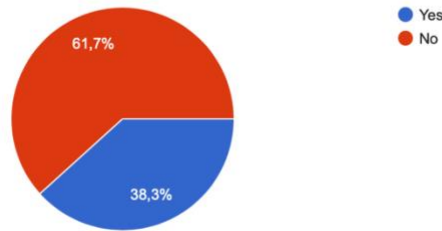


Figure 43. The majority did not notice the editing style.

62% of the answers indicated that the audience did not notice the editing style. In my opinion, there are several contributing factors: the content of the scene makes you extremely involved in the plot. In addition, the usual audience focuses on the storyline, not on the techniques used.

21. “How did the rhythm of the whale slaughter scene affect you?”

This question should give respondents a clue that their emotions are being manipulated, and they should be aware of that when listening to the facts presented after the sequence.

This was an open-ended question. 13 of the 47 respondents answered it. Some of the most reoccurring words used to describe the emotions were “anxious”, “sad” and “chaotic”. Some respondents pointed out that the rhythm was quite fitting and added to the climax of the scene.

21. How did the rhythm of the whale slaughter scene affect you?

13 ответов

Gave me an impression that the movie is biased to some extent, noticing the editing difference

added to the climax, made me feel sorry, sad and angry

It made me cry

It was more sad and heart touching with the rhythm. I think it fits there.

Dont think that its edited just to be more shocking if you mean that

Made me cry

It made it a lot more chaotic and disorienting

sadness and pity

disoriented and sad

Figure 44. The most occurring words used to describe emotions were sad and chaotic.

22. “Did you notice dramatic music in any scene of the film?”

Music and sound in films are generally less noticed by the viewer. However, I think the audience will still be able to spot its effect on themselves.

22. Did you notice dramatic music in any scene of the film?

47 ОТВЕТОВ

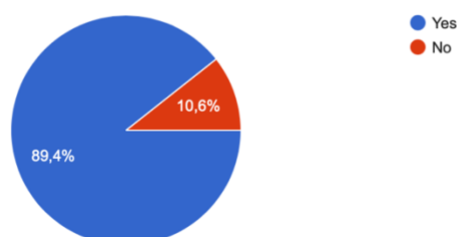


Figure 45. Dramatic music was pretty obvious to the respondents.

Almost 90% were able to notice dramatic music. It is quite surprising and speaks for the number of scenes, in which the music was used. This could mean that the influence of this technique on the audience should be less effective.

23. “Did dramatic music affect your perception of the scenes?”

The question is once again a clue to the respondents to reflect on their perception and impression of the film.

23. Did dramatic music affect your perception of the scenes?

47 ОТВЕТОВ

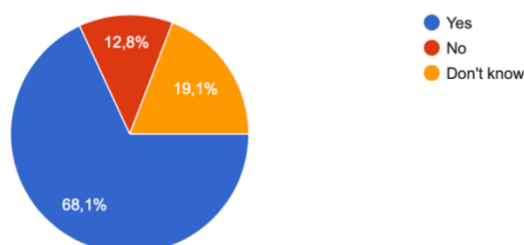


Figure 46. A vast majority was able to recognize the effects of the music.

68% confirmed that music affected them, while 19% were not sure about its influence.

24. “If you can remember any particular scene with the dramatic music, please describe what you felt in the moment (in your answer please specify the scene)”

The goal of the question is to understand, what emotion music did evoke.

24. If you can remember any particular scene with dramatic music, please describe what you felt in the moment (in your answer, please specify the scene)

13 ответов

The whales slaughter scene at the end
I felt disturbed or maybe even hopeless.
anxiety when slaughter
Can't remember any specific scene, there were many
It felt a bit cheap, the facts are worrying enough, no need to plump them up with dramatic music
made me more involved in the story
first glance of sea Shepard ship, felt like it was a threatening machine
Felt more scared by the data
Interview with fishers

Figure 47. According to the respondent, music made them more involved in the plot and caused anxiety.

For the most part, the results are similar to the ones in the editing question. The music caused disturbance and anxiety. It has also increased the level of focus in some scenes. One comment, in particular, had a great point: it noticed that “thriller style” music made the film feel cheaper. The scare from the data was worrying enough for this particular respondent.

25. “Did graphs and animations made the data feel more real?”

The aim was to check whether the pictures and graphs did affect the perception of the data.

25. Did graphs and animations made the data feel more real?

47 ответов

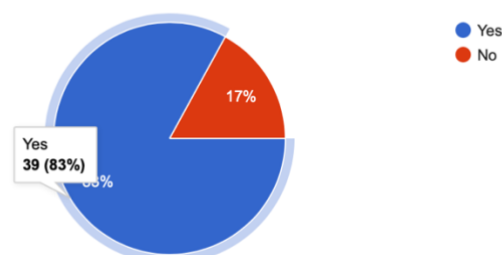


Figure 48. More than 80% agreed that the data felt more real.

83% of the respondents confirmed that, indeed, the information presented this way was less abstract.

26. “Did you find the last scene with Dr. Sylvia Earle inspiring?”

The last scene was extremely emotionally charged, the music helped it as well. I think that it was wisely chosen to be at the end of the movie since she is “the most trusted expert” of the film. Her speech was a perfect motivational ending.

26. Did you find the last scene with Dr. Sylvia Earle inspiring?

47 ОТВЕТОВ

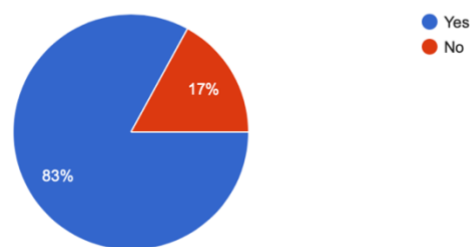


Figure 49. 83% found that Dr. Sylvia Earle inspired them.

83% found the last scene to be inspiring.

27. “What do you think is the goal of the movie?”

In my opinion, this question will clearly show whether the respondents were able to detect propaganda traits in the movie and understand its hidden meaning. They could have picked more than one option.

27. What do you think is the goal of the movie?

47 ОТВЕТОВ

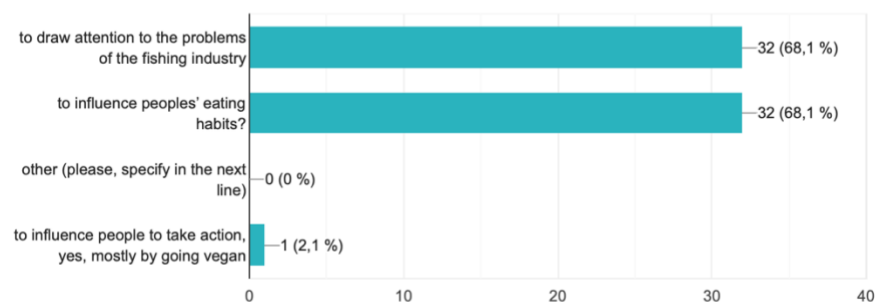


Figure 50. The results are ambiguous.

16 of the respondents chose both options. 15 people thought that the goal was to influence peoples' eating, and the same amount inclined to the first option. This is a very ambiguous result. The general agreement of the audience shows that people were able to understand finding solutions to the overfishing of the fisheries was not the purpose of the film.

28. "Would you consider changing your eating habits after watching the film?"

The answers to the question will show the real-life effects of the film. Respondents had three options: yes, no, to some extent.

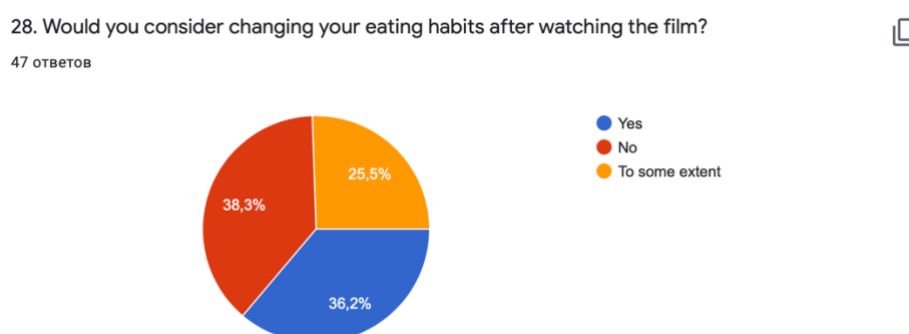


Figure 51. More than half of the respondent would consider changing their eating habits.

The answers to this question are the most exciting to analyse because they will show how many people did change their mind. Additionally, I will count the "to some extent" option as a "yes" because, in my opinion, even this change counts as a real-life consequence.

I am looking into answers from the respondents who stated that they ate fish before watching the film. 17 of 47 responders did not eat fish already, so I will not take them into account. However, 21 out of 30 respondents, who ate fish, were willing to change their eating habits. I think it is an indicator of a successful propaganda film. It moved people enough to keep the idea of not eating fish in their mind. What is more, this indicates that propaganda was not outrageous enough for people to simply disregard it but was concealed to the extent of not being obvious.

On the other hand, 9 people who ate fish did not want to change their lifestyle. 2/3 of the respondents considered change.

The question about the goal of the movie did not seem to influence people's choice to change. From all the respondents that thought of eliminating fish consumption after watching the movie (21), 8 respondents, who thought the goal was to influence eating habits, still chose to stop eating fish at least to some extent. This number could show that people were able to see through the propaganda, however, were still worried by the statistics or cruelty towards the animals. 7 people thought that the goal was to draw attention to the problems, while the last 6 chose both options.

29. “If so, what exactly made you change your mind?”

I am not 100% sure the respondents will be able to distinguish between the first two options because they are so intertwined in the film. However, the options represent propaganda (facts presented in the film) and the filmmaking techniques (emotions causing compassion for animals, especially the whale slaughter scene).

29. If you answered yes or to some extent, what exactly made you change your mind? (please specify)

31 OTBET

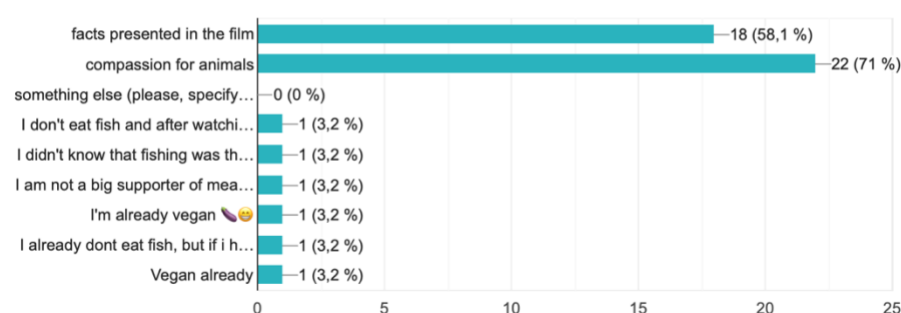


Figure 52. Compassion for animals influenced more people.

The results of the survey show that the emotional connection with animals that was built with the help of filmmaking techniques persuaded more people, however, facts come really close to the same value.

In conclusion, we can see that people were affected by both facts and emotions. The synergy of the half-truths and film techniques made “Seaspiracy” a successful propaganda movie.

Findings.

To sum up the results of the survey, I will point out the most notable findings. What is more, I will confirm some of my hypotheses.

21 of 47 respondents, who were not vegan or vegetarian before watching the film, did consider changing their eating habits. In my opinion, that was caused by the fact that “Seaspiracy” did not show outrageously incorrect statistics. Half-truths made the film a successful propaganda piece.

Another interesting statistic that came out of the survey is the fact that almost everyone despite one respondent who did not eat fish found experts convincing. We see a wider range of answers in non-vegan respondents. This could mean, that the vegan part of the responders could have believed the experts, because of their agenda. This would make the first group of response more susceptible to propaganda.

To confirm or disprove **the first hypothesis** (a very small percentage of the respondents will be able to identify propaganda in the movie), I will examine answers about the experts and the truthfulness of the facts. Firstly, question five, six and seven showed that the overwhelming majority of the audience believed experts were unbiased, qualified and convincing. In my opinion, some of the experts were purposefully discredited by the film (for example, M. Palmer) to make the ones who supported the argument even more credible. Secondly, the facts were seen by the respondents as truth, particularly, the ocean being empty by 2048 (55% strongly believed that) and the impossibility of fisheries to be sustainable (51% did not doubt it). I focused specifically on these facts because they can be debunked, which was already done in chapters six and seven. Considering the percentage of people, who did not find the experts convincing (19%) and were not persuaded by the facts (12% in the question about the ocean; 18% in case of sustainable fisheries), I believe the first hypothesis can be confirmed.

The second hypothesis was confirmed in the paragraph above (the vast majority will find the fact that fishing cannot be sustainable true). Only 18% of respondents doubted that fact. The reason for such a low percentage is the repetitiveness and false dilemma techniques.

The third hypothesis stated that half of the respondents will not be able to notice filmmaking techniques and their effects. Specifically, editing and sound. My assumption was confirmed only partly. While 60% of the respondents did not notice dynamic editing, dramatic music was extremely obvious to the audience.

In the **last hypothesis**, I assumed that half of the fish-eaters will be persuaded to consider changing their mind on the subject of eating fish. 21 of 30 respondents, indeed, were willing to change their eating habits at least to some extent.

8. Conclusion

The topic of propaganda seems to be discussed in the media almost daily. Its relevancy nowadays cannot be underestimated. By focusing my thesis on the subject of vegan propaganda, I was able to deepen my knowledge and identify its traits in the recent successful movie about sustainable fishing “Seaspiracy”. The choice of the movie is not random. Due to the fact that “Seaspiracy” is a documentary piece, it has a high potential of being more influential on the public. I found it especially interesting to study this film in the context of propaganda for a couple of reasons. Firstly, the movie does not use outrageously visible propaganda that can be disregarded by the viewer immediately. It offers the audience a beautifully filmed piece that is filled with half-truths and old debunked studies. In comparison with the Nazi and Soviet propaganda analysed in the theoretical part of the thesis, propaganda tools used in “Seaspiracy” are less obvious, however as effective as in “October” or “Victory in the West”. Vegan propaganda does not have a totality of Soviet or Nazi propaganda, however, “Seaspiracy” creates a “world” where science and government cannot be trusted. It successfully cuts off the only people who can interpret the data and have a nuanced discussion.

The theoretical part of the thesis served as a base for research in the practical part. In the third, fourth and fifth chapters, I described the most used propaganda tools according to the Institute for Propaganda Analysis. Among them are glittering generalities, testimonial, transfer and euphemisms. What is more, I identified filmmaking techniques and expressive means of the film that help to convey the message of the movie in the most effective ways. With this knowledge, I was able to analyse the most used propaganda tools in “Seaspiracy”: transfer and testimonial. Moreover, the film uses false dilemma to narrow the choices of the audience with regards to fish consumption. To examine the effects these tools had on the respondents, I conducted quantitative research, particularly survey research. It had 29 questions regarding the facts presented in the movie and the persuasiveness of the experts. Moreover, it looked into the effects expressive means had on the audience. Particularly, questions regarded editing style and use of dramatic music in the scenes. The survey had 47 respondents in total. My main hypothesis was that half of the fish-eaters will consider changing their eating habits after watching the film. The outcome of the survey showed that 21 of the 30 people, who did eat fish before the movie considered changing their eating habits. Moreover, dynamic editing was not obvious to the people, however, the vast majority were able to notice the presence of the dramatic music and recognized its effects on themselves. After reviewing the outcome of the survey, I can say that the film was able to influence people, what is more, propaganda remained undetected.

The choice to examine the influence of the propaganda through the survey had its advantages and disadvantages. Firstly, the global pandemic made it impossible to conduct qualitative research that would have helped to have a deeper understating of respondents’ view on the problem. In addition, the time frame of writing a thesis did not allow to follow up with the respondents and check whether their changed eating habits lasted through the initial scare of the movie.

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